interpreted this position of neutrality as the Soviet Union actually taking India's side.[118] He nonetheless continued to seek fresh assessments of the state of Sino-Soviet relations, including from other world leaders like Nasser.[119]

American officials were not too worried about Indian attempts to keep Moscow neutral. At an NSC meeting, Allen Dulles happily noted the relative lack of public enthusiasm for Khrushchev's visit in 1960—compared both to Eisenhower's visit two months before and the Soviet leader's 1955 visit. The Sino-Indian dispute was largely—and conspicuously—absent from his public remarks. And the attacks he made on the West while in India were not well received there.[120]

Even as they worked on the Soviets, Indian officials were careful not to upset the US. When US-Soviet tensions intensified in May 1960, after an American U-2 reconnaissance aircraft was shot down in Soviet airspace, the government largely avoided comment—so much so that China highlighted Indian "indifference" and lack of condemnation to try to create a wedge between Delhi and Moscow.[121] The Indian press criticized the US, but Nehru merely expressed concern about the deteriorating situation and called on all sides to settle their problems peacefully. He understood Soviet anger, but was particularly frustrated with Khrushchev scuttling the US-Soviet leaders' summit.[122] Dutt told the Soviet chargé that Delhi did not want to add to the tensions with criticisms.[123] Subsequently, he warned officials against statements or actions that "hurt the feelings of the US government."[124]

Throughout the latter half of 1960, American and Indian officials kept a close eye on Moscow's stances toward China and India. The US intelligence community believed Sino-Soviet strains were more serious than it had previously thought. At an NSC meeting, Allen Dulles highlighted various signs, including a Soviet offer of helicopters to India despite their potential use against China (Moscow subsequently also agreed to sell India military transport aircraft), and the Soviet news agency in Delhi declining to help its Chinese counterpart, which had been asked to leave. The US ambassador in Moscow noted numerous reasons for Sino-Soviet tension. Among them were Chinese annoyance at the lack of Soviet backing on issues like the Sino-Indian dispute, and Soviet irritation that Beijing's actions could ruin its larger strategy in Asia.[125]